> After all that has happened, why do Dost Mahommed and his family remain there in luxury? What has been your treatment of that dog, and what return have you received from this faithless one, Mahommed Akbar? Dost Mahommed and his wives and his children, in revenge for the sahibs who have fallen in this country, should be seen wandering in destitution through the bazaars and streets of Hindustan. May God accomplish this wish of my heart! If Akbar ever falls into my power what treatment shall he receive![19]

One reason the British did not take revenge on Dost Mohammad in the manner suggested by Shuja was the very large number of prisoners of war now held by Akbar Khan.

Some were the wounded who had been left behind in Kabul; some had been given over as hostages by treaty; others had surrendered or been captured and dragged from the caves and villages where they had taken shelter. In all, around 120 Europeans had now been rounded up, of whom Akbar had collected some forty, including Lady Macnaghten and her cat (though the parakeet does not seem to have survived the retreat from Kabul), the widowed Mrs Trevor and the formidable Lady Sale and her pregnant and bereaved daughter Alexandrina.

The first few days had been the worst, as Akbar's prisoners were escorted through the snowbound passes and held in dirty mountain-top forts and remote tower houses. For several days amid 'bitterly cold' winds the hostages had had to ride over the bloody and mutilated corpses of their comrades. Occasionally they recognised close friends, such as when Mackenzie saw the remains of James 'Gentleman Jim' Skinner lying among a pile of corpses near Jagdalak, and had to ask permission to stop and dig him a shallow grave. They also passed small knots of their 'naked, wounded and frostbitten' sepoys 'huddled together . . . Alas! We could do nothing for these poor wretches, none of whom survived the next few days.'[20] It is difficult to assess whether the captive British officers could actually have done much more to save their sepoys, but rumours were soon making their way down the passes to India that the British officer class had saved their own skins while abandoning their men to slavery and death.

One fort refused to admit the prisoners, 'stating that we were Kafirs', and forced them to take shelter in 'a wretched cowshed'.[21] They forded several branches of the freezing Panjshir River 'which was not only deep but exceedingly rapid'. During one of these crossings they were ambushed by